

The Confederates had deployed mines at the entrance to the bay. If an invading fleet were to avoid these “torpedoes,” it would have to steer dangerously close to the forts. Though one of his monitors, the *Tecumseh*, struck a mine and quickly sank, Farragut ordered the rest of his ships to steam straight through the minefield at full speed. No other vessels were damaged, since many of the mines had corroded. As the ships passed the guns of Fort Morgan, they came under heavy fire. Admiral Buchanan, hoping to intercept the Union fleet, then steamed out in his flagship, CSS *Tennessee*. Believed to be unsinkable due to her heavy armor, the *Tennessee* was too slow to ram any invading ships. As the fleets battled in the waters of Mobile Bay, most of the Union vessels concentrated on disabling the *Tennessee*, pummeling it with heavy guns and making repeated attempts to ram her.

The *Tennessee* gave as good as she got. While Union cannonballs bounced off the iron plating, the *Tennessee*’s broadsides ravaged the wooden hulls of her adversaries. But the sheer volume of Union firepower soon began to tell. Buchanan’s three other ships had either sunk, surrendered, or escaped to Mobile. Soon the *Tennessee*, rammed repeatedly and facing 157 Union guns, was too damaged to continue resisting. With her surrender, the fighting came to a halt. It was an overwhelming Union victory, but not without cost.



Union Navy telescope

Alongside the compass and sextant, the portable folding telescope was an essential naval accoutrement. Most officers had two telescopes, a day and a night model.